

Rules

We use the past perfect ¹ **simple** / **continuous** to describe an action in the past which was completed before another action in the past.

We use the past perfect ² **simple** / **continuous** to describe an action which was in progress before or up to the time of a second action.

Rules

We use *used to* and *would* to talk about ¹ **single** / **repeated** actions we did in the past.

We can only use *used to* (not *would*) with ² **state** / **action** verbs (e.g. *be*, *think*).

We use the past simple to talk about a ³ **single** / **repeated** past action.

Rules

When we talk about the future, we use ...

- ¹ **will** for general predictions and opinions, and for decisions made at the time of speaking.
- ² **be going to** for plans and intentions, and for predictions based on present evidence.
- ³ **present simple** for timetabled events, and for talking about the future after time clauses (*when*, *before*, *as soon as*, *after*, *until*).
- ⁴ **present continuous** for fixed arrangements.

Rules

- ¹ We use the **future continuous** for an action that will be **in progress** at a specific time in the future.

We form the future continuous with *will / won't + be + (verb) -ing*.

- ² We use the **future perfect** for an action we expect to be **finished** by a certain time in the future.

We form the future perfect with *will + have + past participle*.

Rules

To talk about ability, we use *can* and *can't* in the present and *could* and *couldn't* in the past.

We use *be able to* for ability in all tenses and with other modal verbs.

We use *can / could* for permission. *Could* is more polite.

Rules

- 1 We use *must / might / may / can't + have +* infinitive / past participle to make deductions about past actions.
- 2 We use *could have + past participle* to say that something was possible / impossible in the past, but it did not happen.
- 3 We use *should / shouldn't have + past participle* to say that somebody did / did not do the right thing.

Rules

When we change direct speech to reported speech, the verb tenses usually go back one tense.

Present simple → ¹ Past simple

Present continuous → ² Past continuous

Past simple / Present perfect → ³ Past perfect

Will → ⁴ Would

Can → ⁵ Could

We also make changes to time, place and pronouns in reported speech.

Rules

In reported questions ...

- we use *if* or *whether* in ¹ open / closed questions.
- we ² use / don't use the auxiliary verbs *do* or *did*.
- we ³ change / don't change the word order.

Rules

We use the active voice to describe what someone or something ¹ **does** and the passive voice to describe what ² **happens** to something or someone.

If we want to say who or what does / did the action (the agent) in a passive sentence, we can use ³ **by**. We only use the agent (*by* + noun) when it is important to say who did the action.

Rules

When we change an active sentence to a passive sentence, ...

- we use the verb *be* + ¹ **past participle** / **present participle**.
- the ² **object** / **subject** in the active sentence becomes the ³ **object** / **subject** in the passive sentence.
- the ⁴ **object** / **subject** in the active sentence becomes the agent in the passive sentence.

Rules

Type	Used to describe ...
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Zero	a general truth.
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First	possible or probable consequences of a situation in the present or future.
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Second	unlikely or impossible consequences of a situation in the present or the future.
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Third	consequences of a hypothetical past situation.
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Form

Type	If clause	Result clause
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Zero	<i>If</i> + present simple	present simple
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First	<i>If</i> + present simple	<i>will, may or can</i> + infinitive
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Second	<i>If</i> + past simple	<i>would, might or could</i> + infinitive
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Third	<i>If</i> + past perfect simple or past perfect continuous	<i>would, may / might or could</i> + <i>have</i> + past participle
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Rules

Conditional linkers that we can use instead of *if*:

- 1 unless = if not
- 2 even if = a 'strong' if
- 3 in case means because something might happen
- 4 as long as / provided that = used to say what must happen to make it possible for something else to happen
- 5 only if = not unless

Rules

We can leave out the relative pronoun *which*, *who* or *that* if it is the object of the verb in the relative clause.